Keplerian orbital illumination

Scope and interface

`paddle/orbital/orbital.py` implements `OrbitalForcing`, a PyTorch module that separates illumination geometry from application of radiative heating. `paddle/orbital/planets.py` provides `Earth`, `Jupiter`, `Saturn`, `Uranus`, and `Neptune` subclasses. These are fixed elliptical orbits for atmospheric experiments, with spherical surfaces and constant spin. They do not calculate atmospheric absorption or solve radiative transfer.

All dimensional constructor arguments use SI: luminosity in W, semi-major axis in m, period and time in s, and rotation rate in rad/s. Angles are radians. Surface longitude is east-positive and latitude is planetocentric. Longitude and latitude are floating PyTorch tensors with broadcastable shapes on the same device. Time is a single Python float in seconds. For a time series, call `insolation` once per time, as the figure-generation script does.

Kepler iterations, substellar coordinates, and inverse-square irradiance use Python scalar math on the CPU. Only the substellar coordinates are converted to tensors on the grid device; grid-sized incidence and masking run there. This follows the atmospheric time-stepping interface: one time, many columns.

`insolation(lon, lat, time)` returns:

- `mu0`: nonnegative cosine of the stellar zenith angle, zero at night;
- `beam`: normal-to-ray irradiance in W/m², masked to zero at night;
- `distance`: star-to-planet distance in m;
- `substellar_lon`: east longitude in the interval [-pi, pi);
- `substellar_lat`: planetocentric latitude in [-pi/2, pi/2].

The first two outputs have the broadcast spatial shape. Distance is a Python float. Substellar longitude and latitude are scalar tensors matching their respective grid coordinates in dtype and device. Horizontal incident flux is `mu0 * beam`.

Kepler’s equation

For eccentricity $0 \le e < 1$, period P, and initial mean anomaly M_0, define

$$M(t) = M_0 + \frac{2\pi t}{P}, \qquad M = E - e \sin E.$$

The implementation wraps M to $[-\pi, \pi)$ and solves for E with 32 Newton iterations:

$$E_{k+1} = E_k - \frac{E_k - e \sin E_k - M}{1 - e \cos E_k}.$$

The initial guess is $E_0 = M$ for $e \le 0.8$, otherwise $E_0 = \operatorname{sign}(M)\pi$ (positive at zero). The high-eccentricity start avoids the poor Newton steps near periapsis that occur with $E_0 = M$. The fixed iteration count supports TorchScript; it is not an adaptive error estimate. Extremely near-parabolic cases require separate accuracy assessment. For the supplied planets $e < 0.054$.

Distance and true anomaly follow:

$$r = a(1 - e\cos E), \qquad f = 2\operatorname{atan2}\left(\sqrt{1+e}\sin(E/2), \sqrt{1-e}\cos(E/2)\right).$$

In particular, periapsis and apoapsis are $a(1-e)$ and $a(1+e)$. Only M advances uniformly: orbital speed increases near periapsis.

J2000 frames and the seasonal phase

For the presets, `time=0` denotes JD 2451545.0 TDB (J2000); time is elapsed TDB seconds, not a UTC timestamp. The orbit is referenced to the **mean J2000 ecliptic and equinox**. Spin poles are given in the **J2000 equatorial** frame. These are distinct frames, connected here by a fixed obliquity $\epsilon_0 = 23.43928^\circ$.

Let I be orbital inclination, Ω ascending-node longitude, and $\omega = \varpi - \Omega$ argument of perihelion. Using active, right-handed rotations, construct perihelion and transverse unit vectors:

$$[\mathbf{P}\ \mathbf{Q}] = R_x(\epsilon_0)R_z(\Omega)R_x(I)R_z(\omega)\begin{bmatrix}1 & 0\\ 0 & 1\\ 0 & 0\end{bmatrix}.$$

The heliocentric direction is $\mathbf{P}\cos f + \mathbf{Q}\sin f$. The direction **toward the Sun** has the opposite sign:

$$\mathbf{s} = -\mathbf{P}\cos f - \mathbf{Q}\sin f.$$

For pole right ascension α_p and declination δ_p, define a fixed planet-equatorial basis

$$\mathbf{k} = (\cos\delta_p\cos\alpha_p, \cos\delta_p\sin\alpha_p, \sin\delta_p), \qquad \mathbf{u} = (-\sin\alpha_p, \cos\alpha_p, 0), \qquad \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{k}\times\mathbf{u}.$$

The `solar_basis` tuple of CPU float constants contains the two columns of $-[\mathbf{u}\ \mathbf{v}\ \mathbf{k}]^T[\mathbf{P}\ \mathbf{Q}]$. Multiplication by $(\cos f, \sin f)^T$ gives (s_x, s_y, s_z). With prime-meridian angle $W(t) = W_0 + \dot{W}t$,

$$\delta_\star = \arcsin s_z, \qquad \lambda_\star = \operatorname{wrap}_{[-\pi,\pi)}\left[\operatorname{atan2}(s_y, s_x) - W(t)\right].$$

This construction fixes both the season at J2000 and the longitude origin. Simply specifying an obliquity and setting all mean anomalies to zero would incorrectly synchronize the planets' perihelia and seasons.

For a generic `OrbitalForcing` without a planet preset, the default basis instead gives $(s_x, s_y, s_z) = (\cos f, \cos\varepsilon\sin f, \sin\varepsilon\sin f)$. Thus periapsis coincides with the northern spring equinox by convention. The preset basis replaces this idealized alignment. The basis stays on CPU when `module.to(device)` is called. Like the scalar orbital parameters, it is constructor configuration and is not included in `state_dict`. Reconstruct the same preset/configuration when

restoring a model. Earlier versions of this note used batched time tensors and a registered basis buffer; callers of those versions must loop over times and reconstruct the preset rather than loading the old `solar_basis` state entry.

Uranus uses the IAU north pole and negative $\dot{W}$. Its `obliquity` attribute is the angle between the **angular momentum** and orbital normal, about 98 degrees. The angle between its IAU north pole and orbital normal is about 82 degrees. Keeping these two conventions distinct preserves the sign of latitude and retrograde rotation. All presets expose east-positive longitude, even where published planetary maps use west-positive longitude.

Illumination and heating

At longitude λ and latitude ϕ, the outward surface normal dotted with the stellar direction gives

$$\mu = \sin\phi \sin\delta_\star + \cos\phi \cos\delta_\star \cos(\lambda - \lambda_\star), \qquad \mu_0 = \max(\mu, 0).$$

The inverse-square irradiance and local horizontal flux are

$$S(r) = \frac{L_\star}{4\pi r^2}, \qquad B = S(r)\,\mathbf{1}_{\mu>0}, \qquad F_{\text{horizontal}} = \mu_0 B.$$

A spherical global average is $S/4$. Albedo, atmospheric attenuation, ring shadows, eclipses, refraction, finite stellar angular size, and internal heat flux are outside this module.

`forward(variables, dt, stage)` applies an already computed heating rate:

$$(\Delta U)_j = \begin{cases} q_{\text{rad}}\,\Delta t, & j = j_E, \\ 0, & j \neq j_E. \end{cases}$$

The default energy index is 4 on the leading variable axis, with keys `hydro_u` and `rt_heating`. For an energy density in J/m³ the heating must be W/m³; temperature tendencies must first be converted consistently with the atmospheric model. The method returns an increment dictionary, without mutating the input state. `stage` is accepted but unused: the integrator owns stage weighting. Insolation does not automatically populate the heating field.

Planet presets and provenance

Orbital elements below are the J2000 values of JPL's Table 1 [JPL]. The Earth row represents the Earth-Moon barycenter. The code freezes a, e, I, ϖ, Ω and uses $M_0 = L_0 - \varpi_0$. It sets $P = 360^\circ/(\dot{L} - \dot{\varpi})$ in Julian centuries, each 36525 days; this is the adopted anomalistic period, not an independently tabulated sidereal year. No other secular rates are propagated.

J2000 orbital elements (angles in degrees, axis in au)

Planet	a	e	I	L	varpi	Omega
Earth	1.00000261	0.01671123	-0.00001531	100.46457166	102.93768193	0
Jupiter	5.20288700	0.04838624	1.30439695	34.39644051	14.72847983	100.47390909
Saturn	9.53667594	0.05386179	2.48599187	49.95424423	92.59887831	113.66242448
Uranus	19.18916464	0.04725744	0.77263783	313.23810451	170.95427630	74.01692503
Neptune	30.06992276	0.00859048	1.77004347	-55.12002969	44.96476227	131.78422574

Rotation uses the polynomial constants and linear spin terms in NAIF's `pck00011.tpc` [PCK]. Pole precession and all periodic corrections are omitted, including Neptune's periodic terms at the epoch. Thus these are simplified reference orientations, not exact SPICE IAU frames.

Adopted rotation coefficients

Planet	Pole RA (deg)	Pole Dec (deg)	W0 (deg)	W rate (deg/day)
Earth	0	90	190.147	360.9856235
Jupiter	268.056595	64.495303	284.95	870.5360000
Saturn	40.589	83.537	38.90	810.7939024
Uranus	257.311	-15.175	203.81	-501.1600928
Neptune	299.36	43.46	249.978	541.1397757

All presets use nominal solar luminosity 3.828×10^{26} W [IAU2015] and $1\ \text{au} = 149597870700$ m [IAU2012]. Irradiance at one au is approximately 1361 W/m². Giant-planet spin conventions represent reference rotation, not latitude-dependent atmospheric winds.

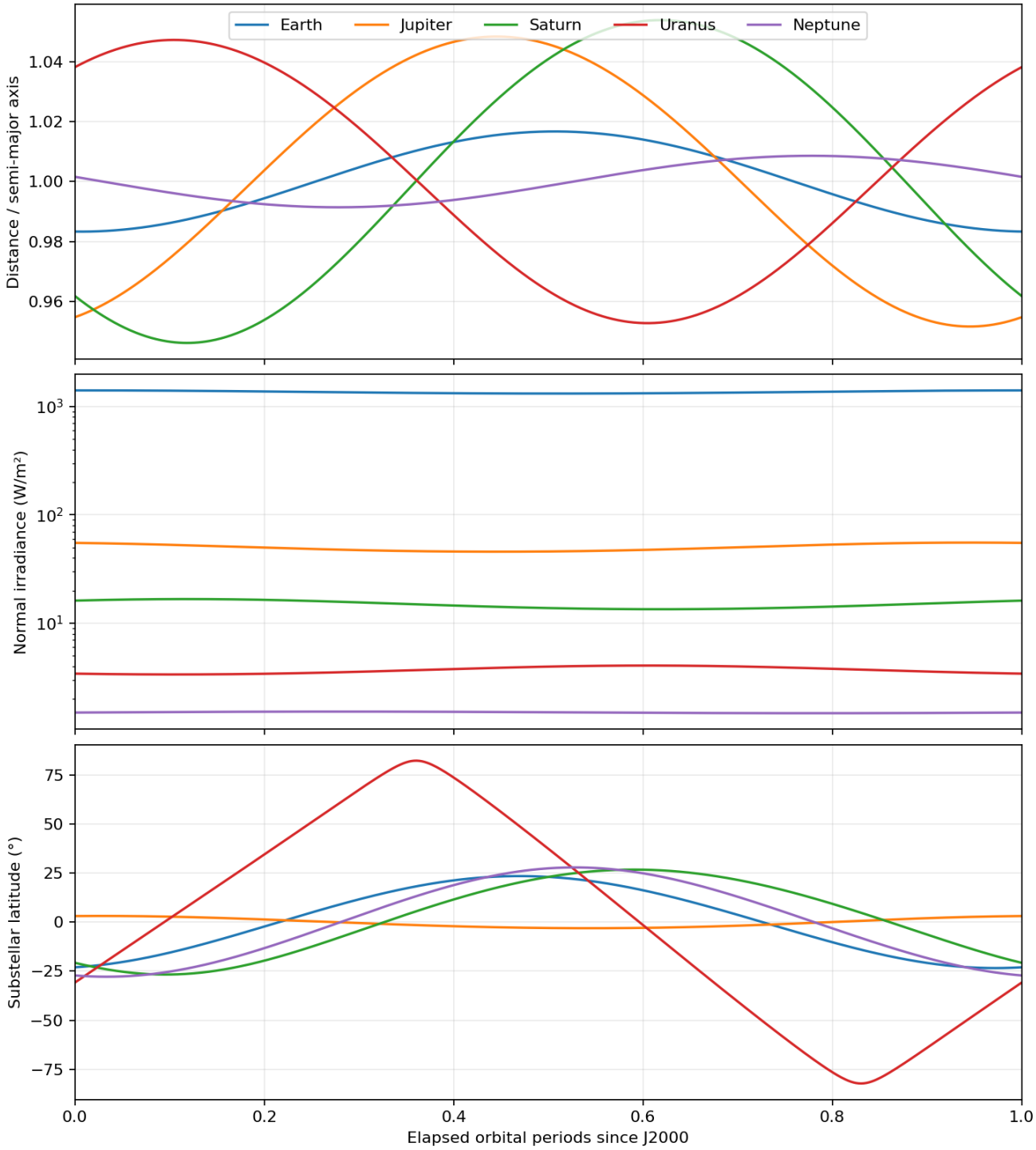
JPL's published accuracy estimates for its time-dependent approximation do **not** apply to these frozen-element orbits. Full orbital cycles in the figures illustrate the periodic model, including beyond JPL Table 1's 1800–2050 fitting interval for the outer planets. The simplified Earth spin also omits UT1, polar motion, and nutation. Use a numerical ephemeris and an appropriate orientation model when precise dates, positions, or longitudes are required.

Examples and reproducible figures

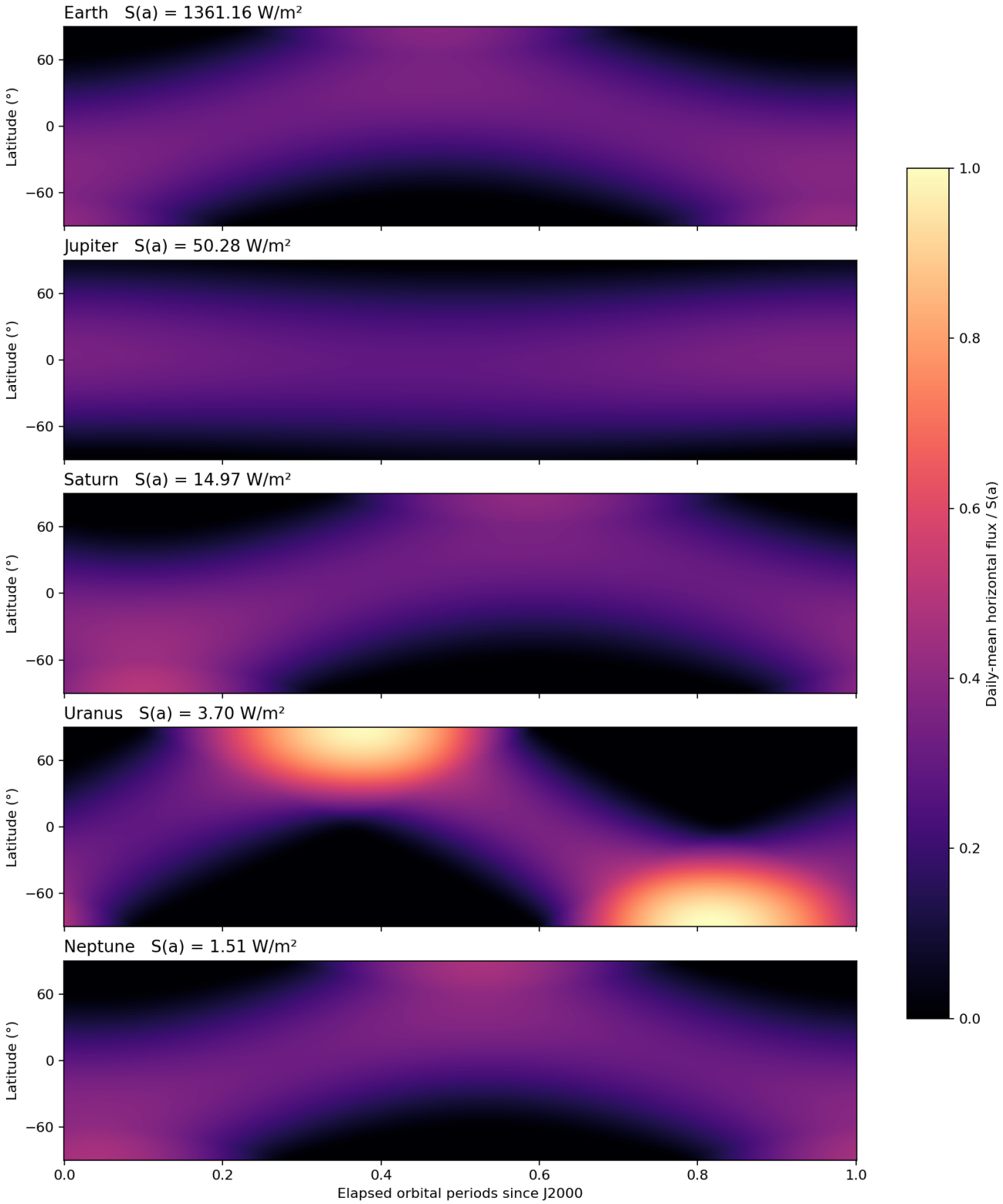
```
import torch
from paddle.orbital import Earth, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, Neptune
```

```
for planet_type in (Earth, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, Neptune):
    planet = planet_type()
    zero = torch.tensor(0.0, dtype=torch.float64)
    mu0, beam, r, lon_star, lat_star = planet.insolation(zero, zero, 0.0)
    print(planet_type.__name__, r, lat_star.rad2deg().item())

earth = Earth()
lon = torch.linspace(-torch.pi, torch.pi, 361, dtype=torch.float64)[None, :]
lat = torch.linspace(-torch.pi/2, torch.pi/2, 181, dtype=torch.float64)[:, None]
mu0, beam, *_ = earth.insolation(lon, lat, 0.0)
horizontal_flux = mu0 * beam
```



Each curve starts at J2000 and spans its own orbital period. Distance is normalized by semi-major axis. Normal irradiance shows the large interplanetary contrast; substellar latitude shows the seasonal amplitude and phase, especially the extreme seasons of Uranus.



Longitude-averaged horizontal flux, normalized by each planet’s irradiance at its semi-major axis. This is the daily mean with orbital geometry held fixed during a rotation. Separate rows share one color scale, revealing polar night, polar summer, and eccentricity modulation.

The plotting script evaluates the actual classes for the orbit curves and uses their distances and substellar latitudes in the analytic longitude average:

$$\overline{F} = \frac{S}{\pi}[H_0 \sin\phi \sin\delta_\star + \cos\phi \cos\delta_\star \sin H_0], \qquad H_0 = \arccos[\mathrm{clip}(-\tan\phi \tan\delta_\star, -1, 1)].$$

Here $H_0 = 0$ is polar night and $H_0 = \pi$ is continuous daylight. The grid uses latitude cell centers to avoid evaluating tangents at the poles.

From the repository root, with Paddle's dependencies and Matplotlib installed:

```
MPLCONFIGDIR=/tmp/paddle-matplotlib python docs/notes/orbital/generate_figures.py
python -m pytest tests/test_orbital.py -q
```

The script uses a noninteractive backend and writes PNG and SVG versions to `figures/` next to itself; `--output-dir` selects another destination.

References

[JPL]

NASA/JPL Solar System Dynamics, Approximate Positions of the Planets, Table 1.

[PCK]

NASA/JPL NAIF, Planetary constants kernel pck00011.tpc, December 27, 2022; bodies 399, 599, 699, 799, and 899.

[IAU2015]

IAU 2015 Resolution B3, Nominal conversion constants.

[IAU2012]

IAU 2012 Resolution B2, Re-definition of the astronomical unit.